

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1989-08-27

To the followers of bahá'u'lláh

1 dear bahá'í friends,

2 The Nineteen day feast, its framework, purpose and possibilities, have
3 in recent years become a subject of increasing inquiry among the friends. it
4 occupied much of the consultation at the Sixth international bahá'í con-
5 vention last year, and we feel the time has come for us to offer clarifications.

The world order of bahá'u'lláh encompasses all units of human soci-

6 ety; integrates the spiritual, administrative and social processes of life; and canalizes
human expression in its varied forms towards the construction of a new civilization. The
Nineteen day feast embraces all these aspects at the

7 very base of society. functioning in the village, the town, the city, it is an 68.6

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71 1 institution of which all the people of bahá are members. it is intended to
72 promote unity, ensure progress, and foster joy.

73 “if this feast be held in the proper fashion,” ‘Abdu’l-bahá states, “the
74 friends will, once in nineteen days, find themselves spiritually restored, and
75 endowed with a power that is not of this world.”69-1 To ensure this glorious

outcome the concept of the feast must be adequately understood by all

76 the friends. The feast is known to have three distinct but related parts: the
77 devotional, the administrative, and the social. The first entails the recitation of
prayers and reading from the holy Texts. The second is a general meeting
78 where the local Spiritual Assembly reports its activities, plans and problems

to the community, shares news and messages from the world center and

79 the National Assembly, and receives the thoughts and recommendations of the
 friends through a process of consultation. The third involves the partaking of refreshments
 and engaging in other activities meant to foster
 80 fellowship in a culturally determined diversity of forms which do not violate
 81 principles of the faith or the essential character of the feast.
 82 even though the observance of the feast requires strict adherence to the
 83 threefold aspects in the sequence in which they have been defined, there is much
 room for variety in the total experience. for example, music may be
 84 introduced at various stages, including the devotional portion; ‘Abdu’l-b ahá
 85 recommends that eloquent, uplifting talks be given; originality and variety
 86 in expressions of hospitality are possible; the quality and range of the con-
 87 sultation are critical to the spirit of the occasion. The effects of different cultures in all
 these respects are welcome factors which can lend the feast a
 88 salutary diversity, representative of the unique characteristics of the various
 89 societies in which it is held, and therefore conducive to the upliftment and
 90 enjoyment of its participants.
 91 it is notable that the concept of the feast evolved in stages in relation
 92 to the development of the faith. At its earliest stage in iran, the individual
 93 friends, in response to bahá’u’lláh’s injunctions, hosted gatherings in their
 94 homes to show hospitality once every nineteen days and derived inspiration from the
 reading and discussion of the Teachings. As the community grew,
 95 ‘Abdu’l-b ahá delineated and emphasized the devotional and social character
 96 of the event. After the establishment of local Spiritual Assemblies, Shoghi
 97 69-1. Sw Ab, no. 51.69.3
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 70 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
 71 leffendi introduced the administrative portion and acquainted the commu-
 72 nity with the idea of the Nineteen day feast as an institution. it was as if a
 73 symphony, in three movements, had now been completed.
 74 but it is not only in the sense of its gradual unfoldment as an institution
 75 that the evolution of the feast must be regarded; there is a broader context

yet. The feast may well be seen in its unique combination of modes as

76 the culmination of a great historic process in which primary elements of
77 community life—acts of worship, of festivity and other forms of togeth-erness—over
vast stretches of time have achieved a glorious convergence. The Nineteen day feast
represents the new stage in this enlightened age to
78 which the basic expression of community life has evolved. Shoghi effendi
79 has described it as the foundation of the new world order, and in a letter
80 written on his behalf, it is referred to as constituting “a vital medium for
81 maintaining close and continued contact between the believers themselves,
82 and also between them and the body of their elected representatives in the local
community.”

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moreover, because of the opportunity which it provides for conveying

84 messages from the national and international levels of the administration
85 and also for communicating the recommendations of the friends to those
86 levels, the feast becomes a link that connects the local community in a
87 dynamic relationship with the entire structure of the Administrative order.
88 but considered in its local sphere alone there is much to thrill and amaze the
89 heart. here it links the individual to the collective processes by which a so-
90 ciety is built or restored. here, for instance, the feast is an arena of democ-
91 racy at the very root of society, where the local Spiritual Assembly and the members
of the community meet on common ground, where individuals
92 are free to offer their gifts of thought, whether as new ideas or constructive
93 criticism, to the building processes of an advancing civilization. Thus it can be seen
that aside from its spiritual significance, this common institution of
94 the people combines an array of elemental social disciplines which educate
95 its participants in the essentials of responsible citizenship.
96 if the feast is to be properly experienced, beyond an understanding of
97 the concept must also be the preparation of it and the preparation for it.
98 Although the local Spiritual Assembly is administratively responsible for
99 the conduct of the feast, it often calls upon an individual or a group of
100 69-2. cc 1:957 .69.6

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71 15 individuals to make preparations—a practice which is consonant with the
72 spirit of hospitality so vital to the occasion. Such individuals can act as hosts
73 and are sometimes concerned with the selection of the prayers and readings
74 for the devotional portion; they may also attend to the social portion. in

75 small communities the aspect of personal hospitality is easy to carry out, but in large
communities the local Spiritual Assemblies, while retaining the

76 concept of hospitality, may find it necessary to devise other measures.

77 important aspects of the preparation of the feast include the proper se-

78 lection of readings, the assignment, in advance, of good readers, and a sense of
decorum both in the presentation and the reception of the devotional

79 program. Attention to the environment in which the feast is to be held,

80 whether indoors or outdoors, greatly influences the experience. cleanliness,

81 arrangement of the space in practical and decorative ways—all play a significant
part. punctuality is also a measure of good preparation.

82 To a very large extent, the success of the feast depends on the quality of

83 the preparation and participation of the individual. The beloved master of-

84 fers the following advice: “give ye great weight to the Nineteen day gather-

85 ings, so that on these occasions the beloved of the lord and the handmaids

86 of the merciful may turn their faces toward the kingdom, chant the com-

87 munes, beseech god’s help, become joyfully enamored each of the other,

88 and grow in purity and holiness, and in the fear of god, and in resistance

89 to passion and self. Thus will they separate themselves from this elemental

world, and immerse themselves in the ardors of the spirit.”

90 69-3

in absorbing such advice, it is illuminating indeed to view the Nine-

91 teen day feast in the context in which it was conceived. it is ordained in

92 the kitáb-i-Aqdas in these words: “it hath been enjoined upon you once a

93 month to offer hospitality, even should ye serve no more than water, for god hath
willed to bind your hearts together, though it be through heavenly

and earthly means combined.”

94 69-4 it is clear, then, that the feast is rooted in

95 hospitality, with all its implications of friendliness, courtesy, service, gen-

96 69-3. cc 1:923.

97 69-4. The translation used here differs from the final published version in the
kitáb-i-Aqdas, which appears in ¶57 and reads, “ verily, it is enjoined upon you

98 to offer a feast, once in every month, though only water be served; for god hath

99 purposed to bind hearts together, albeit through both earthly and heavenly
means.”69.9

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70 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

71 16erosity and conviviality. The very idea of hospitality as the sustaining spirit

72 of so significant an institution introduces a revolutionary new attitude to

73 the conduct of human affairs at all levels, an attitude which is critical to

74 that world unity which the central figures of our faith labored so long and

75 suffered so much cruelty to bring into being. it is in this divine festival that

76 the foundation is laid for the realization of so unprecedented a reality.

77 That you may all attain the high mark set for the feast as a “bringer of

78 joy,” the “groundwork of agreement and unity,” the “key to affection and
fellowship” will remain an object of our ardent supplications at the holy

79 Threshold.

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81 with loving b ahá’í greetings,

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Timing of Feast Observances

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]